Mahesh managed to mumble an apology, "I am sorry, Sir!"

"What do you mean by saying 'sorry'?" screamed Justice Mathematics. "You have to undo what you have done. Do you understand?" He looked above the top of his glasses and seemed as if he would like to bite Mahesh. "Next!" he barked at the peon.

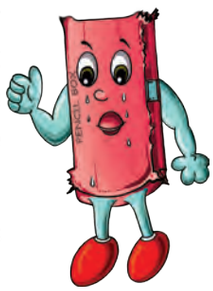


Mr. Geography stood up shakily and went to the witness box. He was in a worse condition than Ms. English. He had no cover, the 'Contents' page was hanging in on its last threads but the worst part were the maps. They had been filled in mercilessly with all the colours in the paint box!

"Yes!" prompted Justice Mathematics.

"My story is quite similar to Ms. English's," Mr. Geography said in a broken voice. "All my fellow brothers laugh at me whenever Mahesh pulls me out of his bag. I especially envy my brother who belongs to Shobitha. She has not only covered him neatly, her handling is so gentle that he always looks as if he has just stepped out of the bookseller's shop, and," he added, "she fills in her maps with a pencil!"

And so it went on with all the books, copies, pencil box and even the school bag complaining about Mahesh's negligence. They looked **battered** and the worse for wear. Justice Mathematics' face became dark when he heard that Mahesh tore off pages from the copies to make paper planes. Mahesh **withered** under his murderous look.



Mr. Pencil Box complained that Mahesh never cleaned it. As a matter of fact, he had covered the court floor with pencil shavings the moment he had stood up as a witness and accidentally opened himself! This was not all. Mahesh chewed him whenever he got stuck for an answer! He pointed at his **pock-marked** body for everyone to see.

The elderly and **ponderous** Mr. School Bag **lumbered** to the witness box with his broken straps and buckles dragging behind him.



"I might as well be a sack of cement," he began in a grave voice, "as that is how I am treated. Mahesh never packs me the night before as all sensible children do, but leaves it till the very last moment. And then, naturally there isn't any time to do anything but cram everything in anyhow. With the result, neither my friends inside nor I am happy."

"Your Honour!" piped a small voice, "I also want to say something."Justice Mathematics looked carefully and found that the voice belonged to a small notebook, much in the same condition as others.

"All right," he nodded, "please come to the witness box."

The young Master Notebook marched to the witness box and took the oath, "Your Honour, it has become a regular practice and I don't know how long I will be able to bear it..." he stopped, all choked up.

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